Even so, the possibility of a widespread CPI-Maoist insurgency in Arunachal is extremely remote. And, as was the case in Nepal during the Maoist insurrection there, the Chinese have shown little interest in the Indian Maoist movement and are unlikely to support it, with ‘Maoism’ being an anachronism even in China. It is an entirely different matter with India’s ethnic, northeastern insurgents who have a long-standing relationship with China’s intelligence services. After the death of Mao Zedong in 1976 and the introduction of Deng Xiaoping’s market-oriented reforms, China was no longer exporting world revolution—only consumer goods and other products from its fast-growing industries. But China’s secret services did not, as the April 2004 arms bust in Chittagong clearly showed, give up their contacts with India’s ethnic rebels. And contacts had to be maintained through northwestern Myanmar, to where the Naga rebels in the 1970s, and ULFA in the 1980s, had retreated after successive Indian military operations in the northeast. Headquartered at their camp in Taka, northern Sagaing Region, they have been able to carry out cross-border attacks into India.

Myanmar’s military, preoccupied with its own ethnic insurgencies elsewhere in the country, has paid little attention to the presence of rebels from India on its turf. Undisturbed by nearby Myanmar Army outposts, a meeting of Assamese, Naga and, Manipuri rebels took place at their camp at Taka near the Chindwin River in April 2014. They formed a new outfit with the peculiar name, the United National Liberation Front of Western Southeast Asia (UNLFWSA), to co-ordinate their activities—and to emphasize their ethnic affinity with the peoples of southeast Asian roots rather than with those in India. The chairman of the new alliance, Shangwang Shangyung Khaplang, a Naga from Myanmar, had been fighting for self-determination for his Myanmar Naga tribes for several decades. In the late 1960s, Khaplang met and escorted Indian Nagas on their way to China for training. When the Indian Nagas could no longer maintain camps on their side of the border, a joint-Naga base area was established on the Myanmar side.

Khaplang sided with Thuingaleng Muivah and Isak Chishi Swu, both China-trained rebels, when the Naga movement split in the late 1970s. When the NSCN was formed in 1980 with Isak as its chairman and Muivah as general secretary, Khaplang was appointed vice-chairman. But it was an alliance that was doomed to fail. The Myanmar Nagas, tired of being